



India based browser - #Epic or #Fail?

Digit goes under the hood of India's first browser and at the same time grills its creator Alok Bharadwaj of Hidden Reflex

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Some time ago, a little known company called Hidden Reflex made waves when it released the world's first web browser for India.

Dubbed Epic, the browser is the brain child of Bangalore based entrepreneur Alok Bharadwaj who is the CEO and founder of Hidden Reflex. "The Web browser is increasingly the most important piece of software on a computer and its usage is growing. The user experience and interface of the browser, however, hadn't changed in 15 years since the initial browsers Mosaic and Spyglass. We felt that your web browser should do more for you—that was our inspiration," said Alok.

The browser itself is based on the Mozilla platform and brings to users certain unique features such as an inbuilt virus checker and a sidebar loaded with applications. Roughly three weeks after launch, the browser crossed four lakh downloads – an impressive feat. In this feature, we take a look under the hood of this seemingly unique browser to put it through the paces and give you our in-depth review. We also chat with Alok Bharadwaj who by his

own admission has been a fan of digit for a long time.

The Epic Browser is based on Mozilla 3.6.7 and hence uses the standard Gecko engine. This essentially means that it is Firefox at heart with a couple of tweaks and changes to its back end. The Epic logo, a tricolour orb is also an allusion to Firefox while at the same time it pays homage to its Indian origin. When we first heard of this browser many of us in the team were skeptical about simply being a custom setup that will install the browser



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with a set number of addons selected by default. Well we decided to ask the creators at Hidden Reflex themselves. "Well that's still roughly the case in that we've been built on Mozilla and haven't really changed any of the code in the Mozilla core. Epic is thus essentially built like a set of addons, but we've also tweaked some of the default Mozilla settings (which one can do in Mozilla Firefox via about:config).

We've basically made a number of tweaks to help improve browsing and downloading speeds", said Alok. The good news here is that users will get access to the thousands of Firefox Add-ons which are fully compatible with Epic.

Main Features

Epic also brings several, thought not all fundamentally new, features to the table. It sports Sidebar apps which gives users the ability to multi-task especially in today's era of widescreen displays that have more horizontal than vertical screen real estate. When you start the browser for the first time, apart from the Indian theme, you'll quickly notice the sidebar which has a long scrolling list of icons or apps that expand when you click on any of them. The company claims that a user gets access to an astounding 1500+ Sidebar Applications. Apps include a word processor, file backup, file browser, video picture-in-picture, e-mail, chat, games, and 1500+ user-installable applications in the Epic Apps Store which are all free to add. We checked out a lot of these apps and as it turns out they're simply fixed width webpages optimised to be displayed on the iPhone! "Many were designed to run on a mobile device or the iPhone and we felt they could be really useful as sidebar apps for regular PC users," confirmed Alok. One of the more truly useful sidebar apps is the

Video picture-in-picture player app. It allows users to dock video from sites such as YouTube into the sidebar, which means you can have the video playing on the side while users can continue to navigate and browse around, devoting only as much attention as you want to the video. The app can also create playlists to which you can keep adding videos that you wish to view next. Quite a useful feature.

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We asked Alok what he felt makes the browser a unique proposition. "Epic's unique in four ways he says. India, Security, Privacy, and Productivity. By 'India' we mean the Indian Language support, 1500+ Indian themes and wallpapers